

REALITY TV

Ticket TO RISE

Reality programming has put the viewers at the heart of a transformation that is allowing them to create a star as well as become one

■ By Kaveree Bamzai

Much before *Pop Idol* was a gleam in music impresario Simon Fuller's eyes, the modest, soft-spoken Gajendra Singh (whose name has now been numerologically altered beyond recognition) created a reality show out of India's home-grown favourite picnic-and-parlour game, *Antakshri*. On September 3, 1993, Zee TV aired the first episode of *Antakshri*, with the exuberant host Annu Kapoor exhorting participants with his own, often tuneless, singing.

SaReGaMaPa followed in 1995, where singers from small towns tried their luck in B-town. But reality TV truly arrived when Amitabh Bachchan put the ordinary Indian on the hot seat and promised to make him a crorepati in *Kaun Banega Crorepati* (KBC). It was a fading star's gamble to re-establish himself in a format that had done well abroad. The show not only changed his life, but also

SOUND OF MUSIC: (left) *Indian Idol 3* winner Prashant Tamang with John Abraham and Amit Paul

Rs 5,000

crore was the advertising revenue that reality shows fetched in 2007

